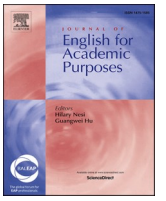
Journal of English for Academic Purposes 83 (2026) 101737



Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Journal of English for Academic Purposes

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/jeap





Developing fine-tuned prompt literacy in EAP: Graduate students' experiences with customized GPT for academic inquiry

Joohoon Kang [a,*], Shinwoong Lee [b,**]

[a] Department of English Language & Literature, College of Humanities, Korea National University of Transportation, 50 Daehak-ro, Chungju-si, Chungcheongbuk-do, Republic of Korea

[b] Department of English Language & Literature, College of Humanities, Hanyang University, 222 Wangsimni-ro, Seongdong-gu, Seoul, Republic of Korea

ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:
Fine-tuned prompt literacy
AI-Assisted academic inquiry
Generative AI in EAP
Learner agency
Critical AI literacy
Digital literacies

ABSTRACT

Given the limited research on AI interaction competencies in advanced academic contexts, this qualitative case study examines how graduate students develop fine-tuned prompt literacy—the ability to strategically craft and refine prompts—while using customized GPT-based tools (MyGPT) for academic writing and research. Four graduate students in an English for Academic Purposes (EAP) context participated in iterative interactions with personalized MyGPT tools tailored to discipline-specific tasks. *Data came* from semi-structured interviews, open-ended survey responses, prompt-writing practices, and AI-generated outputs. The findings reveal four themes: (1) the development of prompt literacy through iterative experimentation and reflection, (2) the strategic customization of MyGPT to support research workflows and academic writing, (3) critical engagement with AI outputs, including the identification of limitations, inaccuracies, and ethical concerns, and (4) shifts in learner identity and cognitive-emotional responses, including increased confidence, agency, and ambivalence. The study positions fine-tuned prompt literacy as a sustained, discipline-sensitive, and evaluative form of academic AI literacy in contemporary L2 contexts. Pedagogically, it suggests that EAP instruction should scaffold sequenced prompting, prompt diagnosis, and verification routines to support reflective human-AI collaboration. Future research should examine broader samples and longer-term development. Ultimately, when guided by explicit scaffolding and ethical awareness, customized AI tools like MyGPT can support not only academic writing development but also the cultivation of critical digital literacies among graduate EAP learners.

1. Introduction

The concept of literacy in second language (L2) education has undergone substantial transformation over recent decades. Traditionally understood as the ability to read and write printed text, literacy has now been increasingly reconceptualized as multimodal practice, involving meaning-making through multiple semiotic resources, including text, images, sound, and video (Jiang & Hafner, 2024). From this perspective, literacy is no longer a neutral or purely linguistic skill, but a situated context-dependent process

* Corresponding author. Office 206, Dept. of English Language and Literature, College of Humanities, 50, Daehak-ro, Geomdan-ri, Daesowon-myeon, Chungju-si, Chungcheongbuk-do, 27909, Republic of Korea

** Corresponding author.

E-mail addresses: jhkang@ut.ac.kr (J. Kang), shinwoonglee@hanyang.ac.kr (S. Lee).

https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jeap.2026.101737
Received 15 June 2025; Received in revised form 20 May 2026; Accepted 28 June 2026
Available online 19 July 2026
1475-1585/© 2026 Elsevier Ltd. All rights are reserved, including those for text and data mining, AI training, and similar technologies.